

► “Win as one”

Apps should work well with other apps by taking advantage of the contracts Windows provides, such as search, storage, and sharing. These principles are more about the philosophy of the design rather than actual design guidelines, but Microsoft has plenty of these as well.

Microsoft’s apps will obviously try to follow these principles, so you can look at them as examples of what the Modern UI is; however most apps in the Windows 8 store follow similar guidelines.

One thing you will notice is that while this has to do with touch, it isn’t something that’s entirely built around touch. One could apply these principles to desktop apps as well.

Microsoft’s design guidelines have to do with how an application should use space, and how it should lay out its content and controls. The most common examples of such applications also happen to be designed for touch.

Getting around the new UI

So now that we have some idea about what Modern UI is, how it got here, and why it will probably stay, let’s look at how to actually use this thing.

What’s immediately visible when you start Windows 8 for the first time is what Microsoft calls, the start screen. It serves a similar purpose as the start menu did in previous versions of Windows, which is to launch applications but it is much more than that.

There are a couple of new UI elements in Windows 8 other than the immediately visible start screen. To use Windows 8 you will need to learn what these new UI elements and conventions do and how to use them. Let’s go over them in turn.

The Start Screen

The start screen is what replaces the star menu of yore – who even remembers that start menu anymore – and adds a few things into the mix.

This is probably the first thing you will see when you launch Windows 8 for the first time – or the first thing you see when it finishes installing.

The start screen is where you will see all all the applications you install listed. It will also list installed desktop applications. Instead of icons, the start screen shows tiles; these are rectangular icons for applications and include the name of the application. Even desktop apps show up here as tiles, but their tiles are visibly different. Windows Store apps even get some special features for the start screen. One thing you will notice is now some